mother took upon herself the responsibility of bringing up her children. The tragedy that would have overwhelmed any but the strongest increased her grit and ‘determination to challenge fate’, says Ratan. They were given shelter at a family home in Navsari, the birthplace of Jamsetji Tata. Unable to adjust to the new surroundings, the family moved to Surat. It was a daring move for a widow.

To support her family, Ratanbai took up Parsi gara embroidery. It was not an easy vocation as the strain to the eye often led to blindness, earning it the moniker of the ‘forbidden stitch’. Still, the income from this was not enough. With few other options, Naval and his brothers Jamasp, Shapur and Behram were admitted to the J.N. Petit Parsi Orphanage in Lal Baug. After his adoption by Lady Tata, Naval could not leave the orphanage until he had completed his matriculation as he was a gratis boarder, but as soon as he did so, he moved to Lady Tata’s residence in Tata House. Young Naval adjusted rather quickly to his new environment and did what was expected of him as Lady Tata’s son. She was, in his words, a ‘fairy godmother’.

Naval went on to graduate in economics from Elphinstone College, Bombay University, and then completed a course in accountancy and audit from the United Kingdom. He articled with the well-known chartered accountancy firm, Woodington, Bubb & Co., in London. On his return to India in 1930, he was appointed as an assistant secretary in Tata Sons Ltd. After a short romance, he married Soonoo Commissariat, the daughter of a well-known wealthy Parsi family.